Sideline — New Feature Ideas

A product & engineering review Focus: features that deepen engagement, save admins time, and give players reasons to open the app between matches. Scoped mostly for your **private group** (free tier), with a clearly-marked track for the **multi-club / paid** direction where it's genuinely worth it.

How to read this

Each idea is rated for **Impact**, **Effort**, and tagged **[Private]** (great for your own group), **[SaaS]** (only pays off if you go multi-club), or **[Both]**. Every idea has a **Challenge** note where I stress-test it so you're getting the considered version, not the brochure version.

#	Feature	Impact	Effort	Track
1	Auto-balance teams using the rating engine	High	Med	**Both**
2	Post-match digest + shareable result card	High	Med	**Both**
3	"Your season" — player form, trends & charts	High	Med	**Both**
4	Seasons & historical archive	High	Med	**Both**
5	Achievements / badges expansion	Med	Med	**Both**
6	Chemistry & head-to-head insights	Med	Med	**Private**
7	MOTM voting + match reactions/comments	Med	Med	**Private**
8	Calendar (.ics) + reminders integration	Med	Low	**Both**
9	Online payments & auto-reconciliation	Med	High	**Both**
10	Invite & onboarding flow	Med	Low	**Both**
11	Multi-club foundation (organisations)	High	High	**SaaS**
12	Sponsor slots / light monetization	Low	Low	**SaaS**

Flagship ideas

1. Auto-balance teams using the rating engine · [Both]

The idea. You already have a per-player rating (`getPlayerScores`) *and* a manual drag-and-drop drafter (`src/app/matches/[id]/draft` , dnd-kit + pitch board). Close the loop: a **"Balance teams"** button that partitions the checked-in players into 2–3 sides with near-equal

total rating, respecting positions (spread the GKs/DEFs), then drops the result onto the existing draggable board for the admin to tweak.

Why it's the flagship. It converts the scoring system from a *scoreboard* into a *tool that saves the admin real time every single week* and makes matches more fun (balanced games). It's the highest-leverage thing you can build because the hard part — trustworthy ratings — already exists.

How. A greedy or "snake draft" allocation by rating, with a position constraint and a small randomizer so the same two sides don't recur; show each side's total/average rating and let the admin re-roll or drag to adjust.

Challenge. Perfect balance is a trap. If you always produce the mathematically optimal split, teams become stale and low-rated players notice they're always "evened out" by being split from friends. Better: balance *within a tolerance*, keep the admin in control (suggest, don't enforce), and consider a "fun mode" that respects a few friendship/keep-apart constraints. Also beware balancing on `provisional` ratings — weight newcomers toward neutral so one lucky vote streak doesn't distort a team.

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2. Post-match digest + shareable result card · [Both]

The idea. When a matchday closes, auto-generate a **digest**: final score/teams, MOTM, top scorer, biggest rating movers, and a clean **share image** ("Tuesday 5-a-side — Team Red 6–4 Team Blue, MOTM: Sam"). One tap to share to WhatsApp, where your group actually lives.

Why it matters. This is your **growth and habit loop in one**. Amateur football runs on WhatsApp banter; a good-looking auto-card gets posted, seen by players and non-players, and pulls people back into the app to see the detail. It also gives the "results are in" notification (Improvements #3) something worth tapping into.

How. Server-render an OG-style image (Next.js `ImageResponse`) from the match + scores data; expose a share button and a public read-only match summary page for the link preview.

Challenge. The obvious version — a wall of stats — won't get shared. Shareability comes from *one* punchy, attractive card, not a spreadsheet. Design the image first, data second. And gate the *public* summary carefully: show first names/initials and results, not phone numbers or payment info that live elsewhere in the match record.

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3. "Your season" — player form, trends & charts · [Both]

The idea. A personal page: rating over time (line), goals/assists per match (bars), best match, current form (last 5), win rate by team/position. Today stats are only per-match goals/assists/penalties with no longitudinal view.

Why it matters. Directly serves "stats and scores regular checking." A number is a lookup; a *trend* is a reason to come back ("am I in form?"). Personal progress is the stickiest kind of engagement for recreational players who'll never top the table but love seeing their own improvement.

How. Aggregate existing `stats` / `player_stats_submissions` + score snapshots by player over time; render with a tiny charting approach (even inline SVG sparklines keep the bundle small — no heavy chart lib needed).

Challenge. Don't drown casual players in analytics. Lead with 2–3 human-readable highlights ("You're on a 3-match scoring streak", "Best rating this month") and tuck the detailed charts below. Also handle sparse data gracefully — someone with 2 matches shouldn't see a jagged, meaningless "trend."

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4. Seasons & historical archive · [Both]

The idea. A `season` concept (date range or match set) so the leaderboard, awards, and stats can be scoped "this season" vs "all time," with an archived **season-in-review** when one ends.

Why it matters. Gives the competition a natural reset and a reason for a recurring event ("new season starts Monday — everyone back to provisional"). Fresh starts re-engage players who fell behind, and end-of-season awards are a shareable moment (feeds #2). It also gives structure to the multi-year data you're accumulating.

How. Add a season entity; tag matches to a season; make leaderboard/awards season-aware with an "all-time" toggle; generate a season summary at rollover.

Challenge. Resetting ratings each season is contentious — regulars hate losing hard-won standing; newcomers love the level field. Don't force one policy: support both a *soft* reset (keep all-time rating, show a season sub-ranking) and a *hard* reset, as an admin choice. And make sure the scoring engine's recency/confidence logic plays nicely with season boundaries rather than double-counting.

Engagement & community

5. Achievements / badges expansion · [Both]

There's already a `public/badges` folder and a `badge-gallery.tsx` component — the scaffolding exists but isn't a full system. Turn it into earned achievements: "First goal," "Hat-trick," "10 matches," "MOTM," "5-match win streak," "Iron man (played every match this season)." Award automatically off existing data and notify on unlock (another habit hook). **Challenge:** badges only motivate if they're *attainable and visible* — a badge nobody can realistically earn is wallpaper. Include a mix of participation badges (everyone can get "10 matches") and skill badges, and surface progress ("2 more matches to Iron Man") not just the final unlock.

6. Chemistry & head-to-head insights · [Private]

You have full team compositions per match (`match_players.team_no`) and results/ratings. Derive fun social stats: "You win 70% of matches when you're on Dave's team," "Your win rate vs Sam: 3–5," best/worst partnerships. **Challenge:** small samples make these misleading and

occasionally socially awkward ("you always lose with X"). Require a minimum number of shared matches before showing a stat, and frame it playfully, not as a verdict.

7. MOTM voting + match reactions/comments · [Private]

You already collect peer ratings; add an explicit, lightweight **Man of the Match** vote and a small comment/reaction thread per match for banter. **Challenge:** a full chat invites moderation problems and competes with the WhatsApp group you can't replace. Keep it *match-scoped and ephemeral* (reactions + short comments on that match), not a general social network — otherwise you're building Slack and nobody comes.

Logistics & convenience

8. Calendar (.ics) + reminders integration · [Both]

Let players add the next match to their phone calendar (one `.ics` link/endpoint) and optionally get a calendar reminder independent of push. **Challenge:** this complements push, it doesn't replace it — a calendar event won't tell them "teams are posted." Low effort, so worth doing, but don't treat it as the notification solution.

9. Online payments & auto-reconciliation · [Both]

Payments today are a manual "mark paid" ledger (`payments` table, payment name/mobile/method on the match). Add a **pay link** (Stripe, or a regional provider / bank-transfer reference) so players pay in-app and paid status reconciles automatically, with gentle nudges to debtors. **Challenge:** this is the highest-friction, highest-liability idea — fees, refunds, disputes, and PCI scope. For a private group, a *payment link + reference matching* (rather than holding funds yourself) captures 80% of the value at 20% of the risk. Only go full payment-processing if you're on the SaaS track and can justify the compliance overhead.

10. Invite & onboarding flow · [Both]

You already have `player_access_tokens` (magic links). Wrap them in a shareable **"Invite a player"** link and a short first-run onboarding (how voting works, what your rating means, enable notifications). **Challenge:** onboarding that's a wall of text gets skipped. Make it 3 cards max, and put the *single* most valuable ask (enable notifications) at the moment of highest intent, not on step 1.

Growth & monetization track

11. Multi-club foundation (organisations) · [SaaS]

The idea. Introduce an `organisation` /tenant layer so multiple independent groups can run on one deployment, each with isolated players, matches, scoring config, and admins.

Why it matters. This is the gate to *every* SaaS ambition — without it there is no "other clubs can sign up." The scoring engine, drafting, and notifications are already genuinely good; the only thing stopping Sideline from being a product is that the data model is single-club.

How (challenge-first). This is deliberately near the bottom because it's a **large, invasive change**: every table (`matches`, `players`, `votes`, `payments`, settings in `app_settings`, etc.) needs a tenant key and every query needs scoping, plus tenant-aware auth. **Do not start this to serve your own group** — it adds complexity and risk with zero benefit to a single club. Only pursue it once you have concrete evidence another club actually wants in (a waiting list, a friend's team asking). Validate demand *before* paying the multi-tenancy tax. A cheaper interim experiment: stand up a second isolated instance for one other group and see if it sticks before re-architecting.

12. Sponsor slots / light monetization · [SaaS]

The idea. An optional, unobtrusive sponsor line on the match summary / share card ("Match sponsored by [local shop]"), or a small "supported by" slot — the kind of thing a local café or a team captain's employer might pay a token amount for.

Why it matters. It's the lowest-effort, lowest-ick revenue path for grassroots football and keeps the core **free**. It leans on the share card (#2) that already gets seen widely.

Challenge. Ads in a small community app are usually a net negative — they cheapen the experience for pennies. Only worth it if (a) it's a *sponsor* (relevant, tasteful, one line) not an ad network, and (b) it funds something players see (pitch costs, end-of-season awards). If it can't clear that bar, skip monetization entirely — the free tier is the right home for a private group, and goodwill is worth more than the revenue here.

Suggested sequence

1. **Auto-balance teams (#1)** — highest leverage, reuses what you have, saves admin time every week.
2. **Post-match digest + share card (#2)** — powers the habit loop and organic growth; pairs with the notification work in the Improvements doc.
3. **"Your season" trends (#3)** and **badges (#5)** — give players reasons to check in between matches.
4. **Seasons (#4)** — structure and recurring re-engagement moments.
5. Everything else opportunistically; **multi-club (#11)** *only* on validated external demand.

What I rejected outright

- **A native iOS/Android app.** The PWA (once genuinely installable — see Improvements #1) covers your needs without app-store overhead, review cycles, and dual codebases.
- **General-purpose chat / social feed.** WhatsApp already owns that for your group; competing loses. Match-scoped reactions (#7) are the right, bounded amount of social.

- **AI "insights" for their own sake.** Auto-generated narrative summaries sound impressive but add cost and hallucination risk; the concrete stats in #2/#3 are more trustworthy and more shareable.